

# Technical writing style

Polishing style

# Tips for improving technical writing style

# 1. Write in the Active Voice



**Active voice:**

**Subject**

**Object**

**Passive voice:**

**Object**

**Subject**

# Why active > passive voice

Normal  
word order  
is SVO

items in  
top-down  
order

less wordy  
and  
confusing.

*The planning committee discovered that the room wasn't available. (active)*  
*It was discovered by the planning committee that the room wasn't available. (passive)*

# Change Passive to Active

- Move the person acting out of a prepositional phrase.

|         |                                               |
|---------|-----------------------------------------------|
| Passive | The test was conducted <i>by the intern</i> . |
| Active  | <i>The intern</i> conducted the test.         |

- Supply a subject (a person or an agent).

|         |                                         |
|---------|-----------------------------------------|
| Passive | This method was ruled out.              |
| Active  | <i>The staff</i> ruled out this method. |
| Active  | <i>I</i> ruled out this method.         |

- Substitute an active verb for a passive one.

|         |                                                   |
|---------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Passive | The heated water is <i>sent</i> into the chamber. |
| Active  | The heated water <i>flows</i> into the chamber.   |

# Use the Passive If It Is Accurate

|                                                       |                                                |
|-------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Typical situation needs no agent                      | Robots are used in repetitive activities.      |
| Active verb requires an unnecessary agent (companies) | Companies use robots in repetitive activities. |
| Active accuses                                        | You violated the ethics code by doing that.    |
| Passive avoids accusing                               | The ethics code was violated by that act.      |

The passive voice can also be used to emphasize a certain word.

|                                              |                                             |
|----------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| Use passive to emphasize <i>milk samples</i> | Milk samples are preserved by the additive. |
| Use active to emphasize <i>additive</i>      | The additive preserves the milk samples.    |



## 2. Use Parallelism

|          |                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Faulty   | My duties included <i>coming</i> in early in the morning and doing preparation work, <i>to cook</i> on the front line, <i>trained</i> new employees, and <i>took</i> inventory. |
| Parallel | My duties included <i>coming</i> in early to do preparation, <i>cooking</i> on the front line, <i>training</i> new employees, and <i>taking</i> inventory.                      |
| Faulty   | Typical writing situations include <i>proposals</i> , <i>the sending of</i> e-mail, and <i>how to update</i> the system.                                                        |
| Parallel | Typical writing situations include <i>editing</i> proposals, <i>sending</i> e-mail, and <i>updating</i> the system.                                                             |



### 3. Use There Are (indefinite phrase) Sparingly

Ineffective.

There is a change in efficiency policy that could increase our profits.

Effective

Our profits will increase if we change our efficiency policy.

Ineffective

There are three problems that this process has.

Effective

This process has three problems.

Ineffective

There are two reasons why we should talk about abandoning our current location.

Effective

We should abandon our current location for two reasons

Exercise: Eliminate there are, or any related form, from the following sentences.

There are several methods of research that I will use.

- There are slowness and inefficiency in the data processing and information retrieval.
- There is a need for some XML code to be learned by me.
- There is a reliance on business to provide product information on the Web.

## 4. Avoid Nominalizations

|        |                                                                                                                                  |
|--------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Static | The training policy for most personnel will have the <i>requirement</i> of the <i>completion</i> of an initial one-week seminar. |
| Active | The training policy will <i>require</i> most personnel <i>to complete</i> a one-week seminar.                                    |
| Static | There will be costs for the <i>installation</i> of this machine in the vicinity of \$10,000.                                     |
| Active | We can <i>install</i> this machine for about \$10,000.<br>The machine will cost \$10,000 <i>to install</i> .                     |

## 5. Put the Main Idea First

|                    |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|--------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Main idea is last  | The writing of manufacturing processes, which explain the sequence of a part's production, and design specifications, which detail the materials needed to produce an object, are two types of professional writing I will do. |
| Main idea is first | Two types of professional writing that I will do are writing manufacturing processes, which explain the sequence of a part's production, and design specifications, which detail the materials needed to produce an object.    |

## 6. Write Sentences of 12 to 25 Words

One sentence, 40 words long

The problem is the efficiency policy, which has measures that emphasize producing as many parts as possible, for instance, 450 per hour, compared to a predetermined standard, usually measured by the machine's capacity, say, 500, for a rating of 90%.

Two sentences, 20 and 21 words long

The problem is the efficiency policy, which calls for producing as many parts as possible compared to a predetermined standard. If a machine produces 450 per hour and if its capacity is 500 per hour, it has a rating of 90%.



## 7. Use *You* Correctly

**Do not use you in formal reports**

you means “the reader”; it should not mean “I,” or a very informal substitute for “the” or “a

“This is your basic hammer.”

|                  |                                                                                                |
|------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Incorrect as “I” | I knew when I took the training course that <i>you</i> must experience the problems firsthand. |
| Correct          | I knew when I took the training course that I needed to experience the problems firsthand.     |

## 8. Avoid Sexist Language

|                                                     |                                                                |
|-----------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Sexist                                              | The clerk must make sure that <i>he</i> punches in.            |
| Use an infinitive                                   | The clerk must make sure <i>to punch</i> in.                   |
| Use the plural                                      | The clerks must make sure that <i>they</i> punch in.           |
| Use the plural to refer to “plural sense” singulars | Everyone will bring their special dish to the company potluck. |

# Eliminate Common Clarity Errors

# 1. Avoid Strings of Choppy Sentences

|        |                                                                                                                                                                       |
|--------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Choppy | Both models offer safety belts. Both models have counterbalancing. Each one has a horn. Each one has lights. One offers wing-sided seats. These seats enhance safety. |
| Clear  | Both models offer safety belts, counterbalancing, a horn, and lights. Only one offers wing-sided seats, which enhance safety.                                         |

## 2. Avoid Wordiness and Redundancy

Unnecessary subordinate clause

I found the site *by the use of keywords that are* nanotechnology and innovation

Revised

I found the site using *the keywords* “nanotechnology” and “innovation.”



|                                                            |                                                                            |
|------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Redundant intensifiers plus unnecessary subordinate clause | It is made of <i>very</i> thin glass <i>that is milky white in color</i> . |
|------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|

|         |                                        |
|---------|----------------------------------------|
| Revised | It is made of thin, milky white glass. |
|---------|----------------------------------------|

|           |                                                                                                                  |
|-----------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Redundant | The tuning handle is a metal protrusion that can be easily grasped <i>hold of by the hand</i> to turn the gears. |
|-----------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

|         |                                                                                       |
|---------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Revised | The tuning handle is a metal protrusion that can be easily grasped to turn the gears. |
|---------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

Unnecessary repetition plus  
over use of prepositions

*This search was done by a keyword search of the same words using the search function of different search engines.*

Revised

This investigation used the same keywords in different search engines.

### 3. Avoid Noun Clusters

|              |                                                                                                                         |
|--------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Noun cluster | Allowing <i>individual input variance</i> of <i>data process entry</i> will result in <i>higher keyboarder morale</i> . |
| Revised      | We will have higher morale if we allow the keyboarders to enter data at their own rate.                                 |

## 4. Put the Topic Sentence First

|                    |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|--------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Topic sentence     | <p>The second remarkable property of muskeg is that, like a great sponge, it absorbs and accumulates water. Water enters a muskeg forest through precipitation (rain and snow) and through the ground (rivers, streams, seeps). It leaves by evaporation (chiefly of vapor transpired by the plants) and by outflow through or over the ground. However, input and output are not in balance. Water accumulates and is held absorbed in the accumulating peat. One of the commonest plants of muskeg is sphagnum moss, otherwise known as peat moss; alive or dead, its water-holding capacity is renowned, and is what gives peat its great water-retaining power. (Pielou 97)</p> |
| Supporting details |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |



## 5. Arrange Sentences by Level

Hydraulic pumps are classified as either nonpositive or positive displacement units. Nonpositive displacement pumps produce a continuous flow. Because of this design, there is no positive internal seal against leakage, and their output varies as pressure varies. Positive displacement pumps produce a pulsating flow. Their design provides a positive internal seal against leakage. Their output is virtually unaffected as system pressure varies.

- (1) Hydraulic pumps are classified as either nonpositive or positive displacement units.
  - (2) Nonpositive displacement pumps produce a continuous flow.
    - (3) Because of this design, there is no positive internal seal against leakage, as their output pressure varies.
  - (2) Positive displacement pumps produce a pulsating flow.
    - (3) Their design provides a positive internal seal against leakage.
    - (3) Their output is virtually unaffected as the system pressure varies.

## 6. Repeat Terms in a New/Old Sequence

Subduction stopped when the continent *collided* with the island arc along its northern margin. This *collision* resulted in extensive deformation of the island arc as well as deformation of the sedimentary rocks on the continental margin described earlier. The *collision* produced a *mountain range* across northern Wisconsin. This ancient *mountain range* is called the Penokean Mountains. The eroded remnants of these *mountains* constitute much of the bedrock of Wisconsin, Minnesota, and Michigan. (LaBerge 111)

## 7. Provide Transitions

first/second

not only/but also

however, therefore

and but are



Choose a Tone for the  
Reader

Learn to control tone

1. Forceful
2. Passive
3. Personal
4. Impersonal

# 1. Forceful

- Use the active voice.
- Use the subject–verb–object structure.
- Do not use “weasel words” (possibly, maybe, perhaps).
- Use imperatives
- Clearly indicate that you are the responsible agent

I have decided to implement your suggestion that we supply all office workers with laptops and eliminate their towers. This suggestion is excellent. You have clearly made the case that this change will reduce eyestrain issues and will greatly enhance the flow of information in the department. Make an appointment with me so we can start to implement this fine idea.

## 2. Passive

- Avoid imperatives.
- Use the passive voice.
- Use “weasel words” (very, several people, quite, fairly).
- Use longer sentences.
- Do not explicitly take responsibility

The proposal to implement laptops in our department has not been accepted because of a number of very difficult issues. To our surprise several people have indicated that the ergonomic benefits of the screens are not seen as not quite offsetting the potential disruption that will be caused by the migration of files to the new machines. The large footprint of the docking station has also been suggested as a possible problem for our employees due to their fairly restricted desk space. Because the need for action on computer replacement is necessary, a meeting will be scheduled next week to discuss this.

The steering committee and I reject the laptop proposal. You have not included enough convincing data on morale or work flow, and you have not dealt with work flow disruption and the large size of the docking station. Make an appointment to see me if necessary.



### 3. Personal

- Use the active voice.
- Use first names.
- Use personal pronouns.
- Use short sentences.
- Use contractions.
- Direct questions at the reader.

Ted, thanks for that laptop suggestion. The steering committee loved it. Like you, we feel it will solve the eyestrain issue and will facilitate data flow. And we think it will also raise morale. I'd like you to begin work on this soon. Can you make an appointment to see me this week?

**This tone is also appropriate for delivering a negative message when both parties are equal.**

Ted, thanks for the laptop suggestion, but we can't do it this cycle. The steering committee understands the ergonomic issue you raise, but they are very concerned about the disruption that migrating all those files will cause. In addition, they feel that we need to work out the entire issue of footprint—the model you suggested would cause a number of problems with current desk configurations. I know that this is a disappointment. Could we get together soon to discuss this?

## 4. Impersonal

- Do not use names, especially first names.
- Do not use personal pronouns.
- Use the passive voice.
- Use longer sentences.

A decision to provide each employee with a laptop has been made. Laptops will reduce the eye fatigue that some employees have experienced, and the laptops will increase data flow. Ted Baxter will chair the implementation committee. Donna Silver and Robert Sirabian will assist. The committee will hold its initial meeting on Monday, October 10, at 3:00 P.M. in Room 111.

## Source

Riordan, D. (2014). *Technical report writing today*. Cengage Learning.